Executive Functioning: Task Initiation, Completion, & Perseverance for TEENS



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Task Initiation, Completion, & Perseverance for Teens

1. Getting Started is the Hard Part: Page 3
This story introduces students to task initiation.

2. What is Procrastination?: Page 4
This story introduces students to procrastinating & why it's important to not procrastinate.

3. Avoid Procrastination: Page 5
This visual outlines 3 different strategies to avoid being a procrastinator!

4. Procrastination & Motivation Reflection Worksheet: Page 6
This worksheet will help students reflect on procrastinating and how they can motivate themselves in their own lives.

5. What is Perseverance?: Page 7
This story introduces students to what perseverance is, and why it's important to persevere, even when things get tough.

6. We Can Persevere Poster Activity: Page 8
Have your student fill-in each strategy with their own definition of how it can be used. Then have them use the back of the worksheet (or blank paper) to create a poster encouraging someone else (or their future selves) to keep going even when things get tough.

7. Finding Inspiration From People Who Persevered: Pages 9 – 10
Students can find inspiration by reading about a historical hero that showed great perseverance (Harriet Tubman) on page 9. Then students will have the opportunity to research another person that persevered. Students can choose one of the 12 famous people listed or select their own person of interest who persevered to research.

8. What Does Your Mind Look Like?: Page 11
This worksheet will require students to reflect on themselves and determine things such as their strengths & weaknesses, their goals, and what motivates them.

9. Let's Review Worksheet…Starting & Finishing a Task: Page 12
A review worksheet for task initiation, completion, and perseverance.

Getting Started is the Hard Part



Sometimes when we have a big task to complete, getting started is the hardest part. Why? Because our thoughts can be scarier than the actual situation. Before we start something, we might think of how much we must do, how hard it's going to be, and how much time it might take. We might also think about the possibility of failure, and the task might be so hard or big that we don't know where to begin. But in our lives, we will have many tasks that we must complete, and that's why it is important to learn about task initiation. **Task initiation** is the ability to start a new task and stay motivated on the task until it is finished, even when challenges arise.



Think: What is a task you must complete, even when you don't want to?

When we have a large task to get started on, it can help to make a plan. You can write down your plan or draw it out. Your plan may seem overwhelming at first, but if you are having a really hard time getting started, pick something easy to start with. You can get your flow going by starting and completing a small portion of the task. Once we are moving, it is easier to stay in motion.

Think about if you must clean your whole house. It might seem overwhelming at first. But you can first plan to break it down into smaller sections. You might need to clean the kitchen, living room, bedroom and bathroom. Maybe the kitchen is a real mess, but the bathroom is not too messy and is the smallest room to clean. In this situation it might be wise to start by cleaning the bathroom. It will help you get in the cleaning mood, but you will be able to finish it quicker than the other rooms and will be able to cross it off your to-do list. Once we initiate a task and start making progress on a larger goal, it can become easier to keep moving until we are finished!



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What is Procrastination?

Procrastination means to avoid or delay doing a task. There are many reasons why we might procrastinate doing something. Maybe we are afraid of failing the task, perhaps we have something better we'd rather be doing, or maybe we really did mean to start a task but then got distracted. Regardless of the reason why, procrastinating important tasks can have negative consequences in our lives. When we procrastinate, our to-do list keeps getting bigger. We may miss opportunities to better ourselves, and we may let our friends and family down by not completing important tasks. Procrastinating can also have a negative impact on our mind. Knowing we must do something, but avoiding it, can cause us to become stressed and nervous. We will continue to think about how much we do not want to do something. Negative thoughts lead to negative moods and relationships.





Think: Do you ever procrastinate? What happens?

So how can we *not* procrastinate? There are a few different strategies we can use to reduce procrastination. Read briefly about the strategies below. There is more information about each strategy on the next page.

1. **Reward yourself:** We can choose something we like to do and reward ourselves with this special treat or activity after we finish a hard task.
2. **Set a timer:** If we are having trouble getting started because there's something else we'd rather be doing, it can be helpful to set a timer for yourself. When the timer goes off, it's time to go to work.
3. **Visualize yourself completing the task:** If you are feeling overwhelmed or nervous about starting a task, it can be helpful to close your eyes and think about how you will feel when the task is complete. Will you feel better than you do now?



Brainstorm: Can you think of another way to avoid procrastinating?

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Avoid Procrastination!

1. Reward Yourself

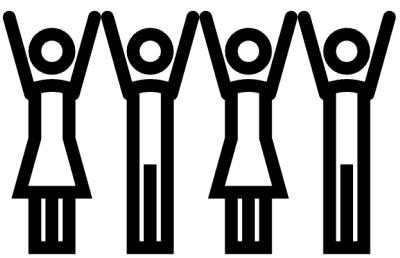
When younger, there may have been times when we were rewarded for doing work by teachers and parents. But as we get older, we usually must create our own motivation. We study to get good grades; we work for a paycheck. But sometimes those things alone are hard to get excited about. We can stay motivated by rewarding ourselves for working hard and getting things done. Think about what may be motivating to you. Maybe it's a favorite food, T.V. show, game, or even taking a walk outside. Pick something that you can reward yourself with and make a schedule for yourself. "First I will finish my book report, then I will go for a walk." or "First I will apply for jobs, then I will make my favorite dinner." Everyone's motivation may be different, but the schedule will be the same. First finish the hard thing, then do the fun thing.

2. Set a Timer

If we are having trouble getting started because there's something else we'd rather be doing, like playing a game, it can be helpful to set a timer for yourself. Allow yourself to do the fun activity for a specific amount of time, such as 15 minutes. When the timer goes off, it's time to go to work.

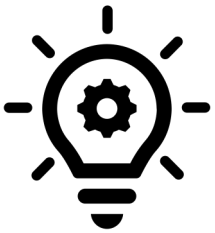
3. Visualize the Task Finished

If you are feeling overwhelmed or nervous about starting a task, it can be helpful to close your eyes and think about how you will feel when the task is complete. Will you feel accomplished, relieved, or proud? Chances are, you will feel much better when the task is complete than you currently do. We feel good and are in a better position to reach our goals when we finish a task instead of procrastinating. So, think about the future and get to work!



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Procrastination & Motivation



Directions: Use this worksheet to reflect on yourself. Why do you procrastinate? What might help you find motivation? Answer the questions below.

1. What is a task you need to complete?

2. What are the hard parts of the task?

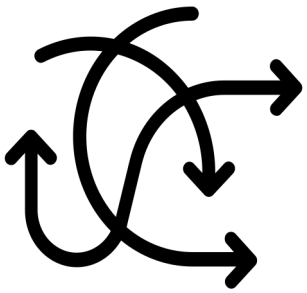
3. What are some things you enjoy doing that you could reward yourself with after a difficult task?

4. How do you think you will feel when the task is complete?

What is Perseverance?

Starting can be hard, but it probably won't be the only hard part. Once we start something, we need to persevere and finish the task.

Perseverance means to continue doing something, even when it becomes difficult or takes longer than we expected. To persevere means to not give up and keep going on a task, no matter what. Often when we start a big task, we will come across difficulties before the task is finished. But we cannot give up just because a task becomes hard! We must keep going and persevere to become our best selves.



Think: Have you ever quit something you started before you finished? What happened?

How can we persevere when times get tough?

1. Take a break: Sometimes the best thing for a tired mind is a break. A break could be taking a walk outside, petting your cat, or having a snack. If you think you might have a hard time getting back into your work after your break, set a timer. But a break for 15 minutes or even a few days (depending on the size of the task) can make you feel refreshed, and you may come back to the task with new motivation and ideas.

2. Remember your motivation: Sometimes when we have been working on a hard task for a while, we get so caught up in the hard parts and our negative feelings that we forget our original motivation and why we started in the first place.



3. Try changing things up: Put some music on that you enjoy, find a new place to work, or organize your workspace. These little changes can refresh our minds.

4. Think about how far you've come: If you are about to give up, think about how far you have come and what you have already done. You've already completed hard things, and you can do harder ones.

Brainstorm: Can you think of another strategy to persevere?

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WE CAN PERSERVERE

Directions: Fill in each strategy with your own definition of how it can be used. Try to include examples that you think would work for you! Then use the back of this worksheet (or blank paper) to create a poster encouraging someone to persevere when things get tough. Fill-in your own strategy for number 5.

1. Take A Break

2. Remember Your Motivation

3. Try Changing Things Up

4. Think About How Far You've Come

5.

People who Persevered:

Harriet Tubman

Harriet Tubman is an example of a woman who showed great perseverance. Harriet was born as an enslaved person on a plantation in Maryland in the 1820's. She had a very challenging childhood that included hard labor, emotional and physical abuse, and separation from her brothers and sisters. When she was 12 years old, she was hit on the head with a heavy weight when she tried to help another enslaved person. As a result of this, she suffered from headaches and sleep problems for the rest of her life.

Despite all the hard times that Harriett endured throughout her early life, she never lost hope, and chose to persevere. In 1849, Harriet and her two brothers escaped from the plantation. Harriet's brothers changed their minds and went back to the plantation. Harriet chose to persevere, and traveled 90 miles to get to Pennsylvania, where she was finally a free woman.

Harriet finally had her freedom and became a housekeeper in Philadelphia. However, she soon decided that her own freedom was not enough. She wanted all enslaved people to be free. So, she returned south to help her loved ones escape from slavery. In 1850, the Fugitive Slave Act was passed, which made Harriet's work very dangerous for her. If she was caught, she would have been enslaved again herself. Nevertheless, Harriet knew she was doing the right thing and continued to persevere with her mission.

Harriet Tubman personally led at *least* 70 enslaved people to freedom and helped many more enslaved people escape on their own. There were many hard times in Harriet's life, but she always persevered.

Answer:

1. What is one example of Harriet Tubman showing perseverance?

_____

2. How might the world be different if Harriet had chosen not to persevere?

_____

Harriet Tubman was a great example a of a hero that persevered, even when things were very hard. There are many other great people that have persevered. Pick one of the people below (or choose your own person) to research about. What difficulties did this person go through? How did they persevere? What can you learn from them?

1. Thomas Edison	5. Eli Wiesel	9. Amelia Earhart
2. Susan B. Anthony	6. Michael Jordan	10. Steven Spielberg
3. Dr. Martin Luther King	7. Bethany Hamilton	11. Ruth Bader Ginsburg
4. Ruby Bridges	8. Oprah Winfrey	12. Bessie Coleman

1. Who did you choose to research about?

_____

2. How did this person persevere?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

What Does Your Mind Look Like?

Directions: What's on your mind? Fill in the circles below by writing or drawing your answers.

My Goals:

When I'm going through a hard time, I can tell myself:

What Motivates Me:

My Strengths:

My Weaknesses:



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Name: _____

Let's Review...Starting & Finishing a Task

Directions: Match the word on the left to its definition on the right.

1. Procrastination _____

2. Perseverance _____

3. Motivation _____

A. The reason for our actions and goals. Why a person does something.

B. Delaying or avoiding a task that must be completed.

C. To continue doing something, even when it becomes long or difficult.

4. What is a possible reason for procrastinating?

_____

5. What is a strategy you could use to avoid procrastinating?

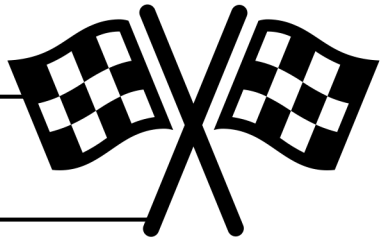
_____

_____

6. What is a strategy you could use to persevere when a task becomes difficult?

_____

_____



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